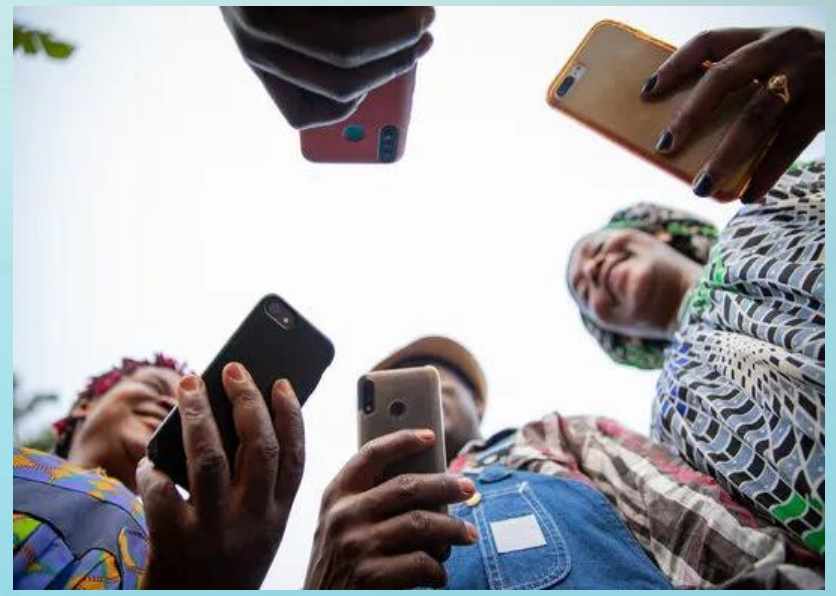
How access (or lack of access) to technology shapes opportunities for young people in African communities.

By Telvin Marikio Kararu
C025-01-0590/2020

Youth, Technology and Opportunity in Africa

This photo essay explores how access to technology is shaping the lives and opportunities of young people in Africa today.



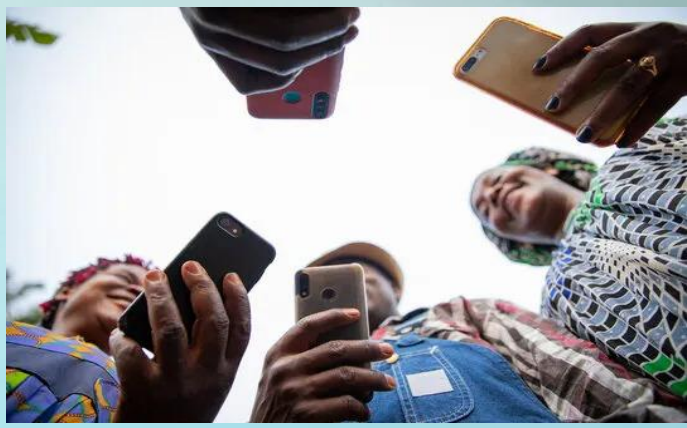
Young people in Africa are growing up in a fast-changing digital society, where phones and screens are now part of the everyday city landscape.

Phones in Every Hand

- In Africa's matatus, young passengers often use smartphones to scroll through social media, watch videos on loud speakers, or listen to music, contributing to a chaotic environment. Loud TikTok videos, blaring music, and shouting phone conversations are common complaints. Some matatus display signs like "SMS only" or "If the music is too loud, you are too old," highlighting the normalization of disruptive behavior. These actions not only irritate fellow passengers but also increase risks, as distracted riders may miss important announcements or fail to react to sudden movements.

- Pedestrian safety is significantly compromised when young people text, listen to music, or talk on the phone while crossing streets. Research shows that listening to music increases crash risk due to auditory impairment, while texting or talking on the phone reduces situational awareness. Distractions lead to fewer head turns toward traffic, longer crossing times, and a higher likelihood of being hit by vehicles. A study using virtual environments found that distracted pedestrians were more likely to be hit than undistracted ones, even after controlling for demographics and walking habits.

- On university campuses, smartphones are widely used for both academic and social purposes. While 98.5% of students use mobile devices for educational tasks, many also multitask—chatting, gaming, or browsing during study sessions. This behavior is linked to reduced cognitive performance, increased error rates, and longer task completion times. Despite schools restricting phone use (e.g., in Singapore, where storage spaces and confiscation policies are enforced), students often find ways to bypass rules, especially during breaks or using school-issued devices. The rise of gamification in education reflects an effort to harness smartphone use constructively, though academic benefits remain limited compared to social and leisure use.



Mobile Money, Youth and Income

Through mobile money services, many young people can receive salaries, pay school fees, support relatives and run small businesses, even when they do not have a traditional bank account.

Computers in Education

Computer labs and personal laptops give students access to online courses, digital libraries, research materials and coding platforms that strengthen their academic journey and prepare them for digital careers.

Afrca's Digital Literacy Programme hads tried to ensure laptops and tablets are delivered to primary schools and secondary schools giving students access to interactive lessons in Math, English, Science and basic computer skills.
In universities like DeKUT, computer labs let us research, code, and access global learning platforms. These devices turn education from books alone into interactive digital experiences that build 21st-century skills needed for IT jobs and innovation.

Cyber Cafés: Shared Access

For students and youth without laptops at home, they're the main place to type CVs, apply for university, print assignments, or even register for government services online. Places like Star Cyber, Calls Mall, and Torrents Cyber employ young people too while giving thousands daily access to digital opportunities they couldn't otherwise afford

Tech Clubs & Communities

Developer clubs and tech meetups bring together passionate young people to share ideas, practice new tools, collaborate on projects, and encourage one another to keep learning and innovating.

Places like GDSC DeKUT, bring together students passionate about technology to learn together, share code, and build real projects.
Across Africa, hubs like iHub in Nairobi, Jericho Incubation Hub, and university tech clubs create spaces where youth don’t just consume technology – they create it. These communities turn individual learners into teams of innovators solving local problems.

Tech Clubs & Communities

Developer clubs and tech meetups bring together passionate young people to share ideas, practice new tools, collaborate on projects, and encourage one another to keep learning and innovating.

Places like GDSC DeKUT, bring together students passionate about technology to learn together, share code, and build real projects.
Across Africa, hubs like iHub in Nairobi, Jericho Incubation Hub, and university tech clubs create spaces where youth don’t just consume technology – they create it. These communities turn individual learners into teams of innovators solving local problems.

Youth Creating Solutions

Young innovators are using apps and digital tools to solve local problems in areas like waste management, farming efficiency, healthcare access and education, turning classroom knowledge into real community impact.

Online Hustles & Small Businesses

Many young Africans use phones and computers to run small businesses and side hustles, from phone repair and online marketing to content creation and freelance digital work, earning income even when formal jobs are hard to find.

Technology supports the ‘hustle culture’ among youth. With just a smartphone, many young people design posters, manage social media pages for small businesses, do online writing or transcription, and even create TikTok or YouTube content for pay.

These digital hustles do not always make someone rich, but they provide crucial extra income to pay rent, buy food, or support parents in a tough job market.

Technology is turning creativity and basic digital skills into real economic opportunities for ordinary youth.

When Access Is Not Equal

Surveys by the Communications Authority and KNBS show that only about a third of Africans use the internet, and access is much lower in rural counties than in cities like Nairobi. Youth aged 18–34 lead in phone ownership and internet use, but many still share devices at home or in school, and some have no access at all.

This gap is caused by expensive data, weak network coverage and lack of computers in village schools. As a result, some young people can apply for online jobs, scholarships or courses, while others are left behind simply because of where they were born.

In many rural and low-income areas, young people still struggle with poor networks, few devices and high data costs, creating a digital divide that blocks them from the same online opportunities their urban peers enjoy.

Gender and Digital Access

GSMA reports show only 35% of African women use mobile internet compared to 50% of men, and women hold under 30% of ICT jobs. Girls often spend more time on household chores, have less time for study, and families prioritize buying phones for boys.
But look at initiatives like AkiraChix and DigiKen – they're training thousands of girls in coding and digital skills, proving that when barriers are removed, women innovate just as powerfully as men in Africa's tech scene.

Girls and young women face extra barriers to technology due to cultural norms, family responsibilities and fewer devices at home, yet when given equal access, they excel in coding, innovation and digital skills

Training and Mentorship

Workshops and mentorship programmes like Generation’s Digital Freelancing and Moringa School training help youth gain practical digital skills, build confidence, and access higher-paying online jobs through hands-on guidance

The solution to many challenges: training and mentorship. Programmes like Generation Africa’s Digital Freelancing course train unemployed youth in skills like data entry, virtual assistance, and digital marketing, then pair them with mentors for paid internships.
Moringa School and county initiatives are offering free digital skills workshops in Nairobi and beyond, teaching everything from basic computer use to AI and graphic design. These efforts have helped thousands move from joblessness to earning $1,500 USD annually through online work – real pathways to opportunity."

Technology for a Better Tomorrow

African an youth are already leading in mobile money, app development, digital hustles and tech communities.
But to unlock our full potential, we need affordable devices and data for everyone, more training programmes in rural areas, and policies that close the urban-rural and gender gaps.
As a DeKUT IT graduate building apps like EcoSwap, I believe technology can solve our biggest challenges – from waste to farming to education – if we make it work for every young person, not just a few.

With wider access, ethical innovation, strong mentorship, and inclusive policies, technology can become a powerful pathway for all African youth to build better lives, stronger communities, and a more prosperous future.